Talking With Dad and the Family About the House and the Savings

One conversation, before you meet with a professional, to get what everyone knows and wants to ask onto one page.

Dad is still in the house. You and your brother each have a view on what should happen with it, and Dad hasn't said much yet. Each of you has heard something different about what Mom can keep.

This guide is for one conversation with one job: put what your family knows, what Dad needs at home, and what you want to ask in one place. It isn't for deciding anything.

Who should be there

Dad, first. It is his home and his month-to-month life this conversation is about. Mom, if she is able to take part and wants to: the house and the savings are hers too. Then whoever helps with the bills or the paperwork, and the brothers and sisters who will have a view, including the one who lives far away. Someone who can't come can send notes ahead.

Pick one person to take notes. It shouldn't be the person leading the conversation.

How to open

Start with Dad, and start with a question, not a conclusion.

- “Dad, nobody is deciding anything today. We'd like to understand how things are set up and what matters to you, so we ask the right questions.”
- “Each of us has heard something different about the house and the savings. Let's write down who heard what, and from whom.”
- Say what the conversation is for: one shared page to bring to a professional. Say what it isn't for: deciding what happens to the house or the money.

Questions to ask

Ask Dad

1. What do you need for life at home to stay steady: the house, the bills you pay each month, the income you count on?

2. What do you know about how things are set up: whose name is on the house and the accounts, and where the papers are?

3. What have you been told about the house or the savings, and who told you?

4. What would you most like to ask someone who knows the rules in our state?

Ask each other

1. What has each of us been told about what Mom can keep, and who said it?
2. What are we assuming that nobody who knows Mom's situation has told us?
3. Where do we see it differently from each other, or from Dad?
4. What don't any of us know yet?

How to write down what was said

Keep Dad's own words separate from what the rest of the family thinks. Where two people believe different things, write both and don't settle it. It helps a professional to see where your family's information came from.

WHAT WAS SAID	WHO SAID IT	WHERE THEY GOT IT	SEEN DIFFERENTLY BY
“I want to stay in this house.”	Dad	His own words	
The house is in both their names.	Dad	From memory. Hasn't seen the deed in years.	Karen thinks it is in Dad's name only

What not to decide yet

These take someone who knows your state's rules and has seen the papers, and your notes are what make that conversation a good one. Leave them open.

- What happens to the house.
- Whether anything should be moved, retitled, given away or spent.
- Who is right about what Mom can keep.

- Whether any legal or financial planning is needed.

What you can decide today

- Who will write up the notes and send them to everyone.
- Who will look for each paper: the deed, the statements, the beneficiary forms.
- Who will take each question to your Medicaid planner, an elder law attorney or a licensed financial professional.
- When you'll talk again.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't resolve a disagreement or tell you what a professional will say. It gets your family to one page, with Dad's words at the top and the differences left on it. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

Your family has talked it through, with Dad's words at the top of the page and the open questions written down. The planning interview asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report, so everyone walks into the next conversation about paying for Mom's care with the same page.

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